



IMAGE MANAGEMENT SOFTWARE

Adobe Photoshop Album 2.0

Our Verdict: Adobe Photoshop Album 2.0 is an image manager with a neat and simple interface for importing photographs. It allows for creation of your own albums, slideshows, VCDs, eCards, calendar, and photo book. It provides you with more templates than you would need for creating that special album or calendar. Photoshop Album 2.0 does all the necessary optimisations for printing an album on your desktop printer.

Images can be hierarchically tagged and segregated into different categories,

facilitating easier search and retrieval. There are many touch-up options that allow you to manipulate images and straighten out rough edges. Adobe Photoshop Album 2.0 also gives you the option to back up your photos to CD or DVD or to another machine on your network. It also has options for incremental backup.



Runner-Up: Picasa 2

LINUX DISTRIBUTIONS

Linux For Power Users

SuSE 9.3 Professional

Our Verdict: Most Linux distros have acceptable user interfaces, but SuSE has always been different. Now they have even mastered the art on X.Org, which replaces the XFree86 X-server.

The KDE of SuSE 9.3 has such a polished look and feel that even the best-looking Windows is no match. The five-CD installation pack contains everything you can dream of. You can set up various servers just as with any other power user based distros such as RedHat. Well, that's no big deal in itself, but where SuSE

comes good is the way it customises individual packages to look and work better.

The notable upgrades in the distro are Linux Kernel 2.6.11, GCC 3.3.5, glibc 2.3.4, X.Org 6.8.2, Open Office 2.0 and Eclipse 3.0.1.

The new Linux Kernel plays a major role in hardware detection. We recommend SuSE 9.3 as a complete package for any user.



Runner-Up: Asus K8S-MX2

Windows Replacements

Xandros Desktop OS

Our Verdict: Linux as a desktop OS is gaining a lot of attention. The trend to make this pro server OS penetrate more and more homes as a user-friendly desktop OS has forced it to clone the Windows interface. Xandros is one such Linux distribution: it apes certain Windows interfaces so the migration becomes easier for regular Windows users.

The striking feature here is the graphical installation procedure, with a very helpful partition manager that makes sure even a novice can create successful Linux partitions without disturbing the existing FAT and NTFS partitions.

The partition manager of this distro is so good that Microsoft can probably take a lesson or two from the folks at Xandros! The elegant file manager provides the user with easy access to the PC's drives, CD/DVD drive, network shares, etc. Xandros comes loaded with the Mozilla and Firefox browsers, CodeWeavers CrossOver Office 4.1, and 'Xandros Network', which is a tool that helps you organise installed software and download newer ones.



Runner-Up: Linspire 5.0

Contour Design's Roller Mouse

Contour Design's Roller Mouse consists of a roller bar that lets you move the cursor around and click on icons. It works in conjunction with a keyboard and can also act as its base; the roller bar and button then falls within easy reach of your thumbs. The roller bar doubles as the left-click button.

Sensitivity can be easily adjusted—by tightening or loosening the knob at the base. Windows ME and later editions of Windows install the necessary drivers, so all you need is a free USB port.

If you are still wondering why this product is unique, then here's the story: a regular mouse makes you move one hand away from the keyboard, putting your shoulder in an awkward, stress-inducing position. The Roller Mouse is an innovation by which you can have the function of your mouse right under your keyboard: you won't need to move your arm any more to reach out for a mouse!



Showstoppers!